

The Process of Being Chosen

We are going to continue from last Sunday and last Wednesday night. Open to Matthew 19, and we will pass in review.

We have been looking at this statement:

The first shall be last, and the last shall be first: for many be called, but few chosen.

How many remember Sunday service, the mother of the sons of Zebedee, and how Jesus settled the indignation of the ten by saying that rank in the kingdom of God is not made by people who have authority forcing their will on other people?

He said greatness in the kingdom comes this way:

Whosoever will be great among you, let him be your minister.

The word there means servant.

We found there is a higher call than that. He that is chief among you, he that is first among you, he that comes in first, let him be your servant. The King James lists it as servant, but the Greek says slave.

Even though there are apostolic, prophetic, teaching, pastoral, evangelistic, governmental, helps, and prayer ministry calls, inside those calls there is a higher call than simply being great among you. If you want to come in absolutely first, make yourself a slave.

Those who make themselves first and live for themselves come in last in His kingdom. That does not mean they do not live well here. They may live very well here. But you will not be dressed there the same way you are here if you have made yourself first.

For years I did not really know what "many are called, but few are chosen" meant. Most of the preaching I heard on it was in the light of some kind of joke. I never heard serious preaching on the householder who hired laborers into the vineyard, which represented the rewards of the kingdom.

One man worked twelve full hours and got paid for one. Another worked one hour and got paid the same. People dug different messages out of that parable: the first hour, the third, sixth, ninth, and eleventh. I have heard messages trying to explain God's grace: "Are you angry because I have made you equal?"

We preached that it is not based on your works or how long you work, but on the grace by which He has made us equal.

That never seemed very fair. A man works twelve hours, another works one, and they both get paid the same. How do you handle that parable?

Most of the time, we skipped it and went to the good stuff: speak to the mountain; He became poor to make you rich. Go to the good stuff. You do not want to stay around the parable where one man labors twelve hours for a day's pay, and another gets by with one hour and receives the same.

Would you be upset? Sure. That is what Jesus is talking about.

I believe we can understand it. In uncovering it, I am getting wealthier by the moment.

To understand this parable, we have to back up to the rich young ruler.

Mark 10 teaches the same thing: the first will be last, the last first, and the encounter with the mother of the sons of Zebedee. Mark leaves out only the parable of the householder who sent laborers into the vineyard. Matthew includes it, so we will stay with Matthew.

Matthew 19:16 says:

And, behold, one came and said unto him, Good Master, what good thing shall I do, that I may have eternal life?

And he said unto him, Why callest thou me good? there is none good but one, that is, God: but if thou wilt enter into life, keep the commandments.

Notice Jesus' reaction to this rich young ruler. The man approached Him and said, "Good Master, what good thing must I do?"

I have never seen Jesus handle someone quite like He handled this man. Jesus said, "Do not call Me good."

Some people threw themselves down and worshiped Him. One man who had been healed worshiped Him after Jesus revealed Himself as the Son of God. That seems beyond calling someone good.

Sometimes the word worship is used for admiration, as when Jesus said you will have the worship of those you sit at meat with: the admiration of those who know you best when you take the low room and are exalted.

But this rich young ruler did not throw himself down and worship. He walked up and said, "Good Master, what good thing must I do to enter eternal life?"

Why did Jesus sharply say, "Do not call Me good; there is only One good"?

The rich young ruler loved God, and he proved it by keeping the commandments. He said he had kept them from his youth. But he was used to buying his way onto the boards of the Pharisees. That is what money does. If you want to be on some boards, I can get you on several international

boards if you have about fifty thousand dollars. You may be in an advisory capacity, and the only time they contact you may be when they have a project, but you will be on the board.

When you walk in with money, you carry authority. Businessmen have an air about them. They are used to giving commands, and they assume people will jump and do their bidding. When we flew our own airplane, sometimes wealthy men would land in Learjets. They would come striding in with ostrich-skin briefcases and two accountants trying to keep up. I felt the urge to run over and open the door for them because they carried that kind of authority.

They have backing to get things done.

This man was used to getting into anything he wanted using his money. Flattery will get you everywhere with some people. Even if they know you are a dog, tell them how nice they are and before long they will buy you ice cream.

Preachers can be like that. Go tell them how good they did and that they are the best teacher you have ever heard. Pretty soon you are on the inside.

The only one it does not work on is Jesus.

"Good Master."

He says, "Do not call Me good."

Later He said, "If you want to be perfect, sell everything you have, and do not bring the money to Me. I cannot be bought. Go give it to the poor. Then come and follow Me."

The rich young ruler did not expect it to cost that much to get on the inside.

He was not a bad man. He kept the commandments. He was just used to having his way.

Jesus said:

If thou wilt enter into life, keep the commandments.

He saith unto him, Which? Jesus said, Thou shalt do no murder, Thou shalt not commit adultery, Thou shalt not steal, Thou shalt not bear false witness, Honour thy father and thy mother: and, Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself.

The commandment in verse 19 was the one he could not keep. If he could love his neighbor as himself, he could have given his fortune away.

The young man said:

All these things have I kept from my youth up: what lack I yet?

Jesus said unto him, If thou wilt be perfect, go and sell that thou hast, and give to the poor, and thou shalt have treasure in heaven: and come and follow me.

But when the young man heard that saying, he went away sorrowful: for he had great possessions.

Then Jesus said:

Verily I say unto you, That a rich man shall hardly enter into the kingdom of heaven.

And again I say unto you, It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle, than for a rich man to enter into the kingdom of God.

The disciples were exceedingly amazed:

Who then can be saved?

They knew how serious the problem was. Unfortunately, it still exists today, even though we have a new nature.

Jesus beheld them and loved them. He looked on them with compassion for their dilemma and said:

With men this is impossible; but with God all things are possible.

In their present unregenerated spiritual nature, this was impossible. But with God it was possible. They were scheduled for a change of nature.

Peter jumps in and says what many of us are too humble to say:

Behold, we have forsaken all, and followed thee; what shall we have therefore?

What do we get?

When I first got into this teaching, I thought I was much too humble to ask what I would get if I forsook everything. But I certainly was not too humble to meditate the living daylights out of the answer Jesus gave Peter.

I like Peter. There is much in the Bible we may not have known if Peter the mouth had not been there. He had something to say about everything. "Look, the tree You cursed is withered away." In the boat, "If it be You, bid me come." He jumped out, walked on the water, started sinking, and cried, "Help!"

But I would rather be a wet water-walker than a dry boat-sitter. I hate sitting in the boat. What I like about Jesus is that when I take one of those occasional walks and sink, He puts me back in the boat.

Jesus answered Peter:

Verily I say unto you, That ye which have followed me, in the regeneration when the Son of man shall sit in the throne of his glory, ye also shall sit upon twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel.

Did you notice He did not say those were the only twelve thrones? From what I understand, there are hundreds and hundreds of them. But He says they will sit on a particular twelve, judging the twelve tribes of Israel.

Then verse 29:

And every one that hath forsaken houses, or brethren, or sisters, or father, or mother, or wife, or children, or lands, for my name's sake, shall receive an hundredfold, and shall inherit everlasting life.

But many that are first shall be last; and the last shall be first.

At that point, it is hard to know what that last verse means. But by the time you journey through the parable of the laborers and then the encounter with the mother of the sons of Zebedee, Jesus explains it. He who is chief among you, he who is first among you, shall be your slave.

So the one who makes himself first comes in last. The one who makes himself the servant and slave comes in first.

From the rich young ruler through the parable to that encounter, Jesus says incredible things. One reason the body of Christ cannot see what He is saying is that we are trying to make it say exactly the opposite of what it says.

Most of us interpret the parables with ourselves on our minds, not eternity. Practically the only thing Jesus taught on in these passages was your reward later.

If I make myself first and serve myself, I will not understand this passage. Self on my mind will cloud my judgment and discernment.

Thank God for praying in the Holy Ghost. Praying in tongues is a revelation gift. It does not matter if you are Greed City. If someone can get you praying three or four hours a day in the Holy Ghost, it will work. The Holy Ghost was waiting for a chance like that. He will pray you beyond greed, deliver you from it, become your Teacher, and start teaching you things.

I found out the biggest problem I had was not the devil. It was me.

Jesus gave me power over all the power of the enemy. When He destroyed the man of sin that used to live in me, He destroyed the ability of my body and its occasional nature-flings to be victorious. From the day I was born again, I was totally set free. He wants me to know that.

I have enough deposited inside my spirit to walk out of anything.

When you pray in the Holy Ghost, He brings that new nature forward and conquers the rest of your soul.

When you die to this world in the mortification process of praying in tongues, you start thinking of heaven. You become more heavenly minded. You think of the power, salvation, and your reward over there. When those things happen, passages begin to open up.

I remember when I would taxi my airplane so I could tie it up next to Charles Capps and Jerry Savelle's, then go in and teach a camp meeting. I liked tying my plane next to theirs. That was my faith symbol: "I have faith. I do not operate out of a trunk."

I like good things. You do not think I like Lexuses? I like them next to a Dodge Ram. Who does not like those things? I like fine clothes. They look good in my closet. I like those things, but they do not interest me much anymore.

I really have only one interest now: trading my life here for His life over there. Everything exists to serve there. All the money exists to serve the kingdom of God now and then. All my energy, strength, where I go, what I do, all of it serves.

I can hold off here, but I do not want to hold off over there.

Jesus said:

| If any man will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross, and follow me.

Not having anything does not bother me. Not being able to do anything bothers me more. Peace covers the rest.

I do not even mind persecution. Mark 10 says that any man who leaves father, mother, houses, and lands will have a hundredfold in this life, with persecutions.

I know what persecution is. I do not mind it when it is persecution for righteousness' sake. Persecution is not having too little money to do what you are supposed to do. He said you are supposed to have provision. Persecution is not sickness and disease. He has not called me to suffer that.

Persecution is when there are people He really loves, but every time He sends missionaries in, they eat them. He loves them and wants them to stop eating His missionaries. They may put you in boiling water and tie you up. He sends you in to testify, preach, work signs and wonders, and get some of them saved. They may still eat you.

That is persecution.

In this life you will have a hundredfold of houses, lands, mothers, brothers, and sisters, along with persecution. In the life to come, those houses, lands, mothers, brothers, and sisters you inherited are the reward, the treasure you laid up in heaven.

That is what He expects you to do.

Mark 10:29 says:

There is no man that hath left house, or brethren, or sisters, or father, or mother, or wife, or children, or lands, for my sake, and the gospel's,

But he shall receive an hundredfold now in this time, houses, and brethren, and sisters, and mothers, and children, and lands, with persecutions; and in the world to come eternal life.

But many that are first shall be last; and the last first.

Notice what He says you will inherit in this lifetime: houses, brethren, sisters, mothers, children, and lands. He does not include a hundredfold return on the wives you sowed.

Peter asked, "We have forsaken all to follow You. What do we get?" Jesus said, "In this life, a hundredfold. In eternity, the reward that goes with it."

Go back to Matthew 19. When the rich young ruler asked, "What do I lack?" Jesus answered, "If you want to be perfect, sell what you have, give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven."

What treasure? What treasure could He be talking about? He said in this life houses, lands, mothers, fathers, sisters, and brothers a hundredfold. In eternal life, they are the treasure you laid up there.

How many were in the upper room? One hundred twenty. On the day of Pentecost, they were born again. The twelve were there, and the mother of Jesus was there. So not just the twelve went out and answered the call. The other 108 were born again, filled with the Holy Ghost, and turned loose on the world.

The twelve apostles gave the church her foundation, and the 108 also went out working miracles and preaching Jesus. The apostles wrote the canon of Scripture, the legacy we have in the Gospels and epistles. Some apostles born out of due season, such as Paul and others, wrote some of the books.

But out of the 120 who went out that day, you and I are somehow a result of that. If we were not directly saved by one of their preachings, it was someone they preached to, and someone they preached to, spreading through the nations. If there were periods of darkness, somebody recovered a Bible, read what those men wrote, got saved, and the chain began again.

Somehow the whole world is linked to that 120. They inherited nations, houses, mothers, brothers, and sisters by the untold millions.

Directly or indirectly, thousands of people will be affected by what you do with your life.

Jesus said that in this life your reward is houses, lands, mothers, brothers, sisters, and fathers. In eternity, for any man who has forsaken all, there is a throne available.

Rick Joyner's books, *The Final Quest* and *The Call*, amazed me when he described all those thrones. I had always thought they were special positions for only a few people, undoubtedly filled in Jesus' day by the apostles. I never dreamed that when Jesus said the first will be last and the last first, no matter what generation we lived in, if we made ourselves servants, we had a chance of being made first.

You are not going to get something like that without finding out how to separate your life to Him. He does not seem as interested in how long you gave your life as in the condition of your heart. Whether it was one hundred years or five years before martyrdom, He is looking for people who can rule and reign with Him.

Matthew 19:30 says:

But many that are first shall be last; and the last shall be first.

Then to explain that, Matthew 20 gives a parable. Verse 16 says:

So the last shall be first, and the first last: for many be called, but few chosen.

Those two verses show that Jesus did not change the subject. You cannot legally leave Matthew 20:1-16 out and trust your meaning.

I used to slice pieces out of that parable and teach anything I wanted, especially grace versus works. I could make it sound good, but I could not make all the verses that belonged together fit.

One man took a shot at it by studying church history, using the first, third, sixth, ninth, and eleventh hours to document major visitations in the church. He said the eleventh-hour laborer reaped the benefit of what the church learned in all the earlier visitations and received the same reward in one hour.

That sounded good, but there is one problem. If God had a visitation at Pentecost, then later visitations through history, and the eleventh-hour church finally gathered all that wisdom, you just made everything sovereign and dispensational.

Are you telling me that thirty seconds after Jesus said, "It is finished," and gave power to the church, God held things back because it was not time for some dispensation? Could I not have what He gave the church in the third, sixth, ninth, or eleventh hour? I thought it was finished when He said it was finished.

I do not like the idea of waiting on a time period. I have grown accustomed to the Scripture that says:

| To him that believeth all things are possible.

People like sovereignty because it means you can be ugly as sin, and one day He will just pour it all out on you. People like sovereignty because it does not have much to do with them. You do not have to believe or do anything. Just be there.

Some say the next move of God is sovereign: no fasting and praying, nobody getting glory for it, God just moving by His sovereignty.

That is not right. That would mean in the Dark Ages God decided to let everyone go to hell because He did not feel like moving. If God sovereignly saves people by visiting them without human involvement, then He is deciding who goes to hell and who does not.

Scripture says:

| How shall they hear without a preacher? and how shall they preach, except they be sent?

You and I have authority for revival. If you do not pray, intervene, and do something, people go to hell. It is in your hands.

So much for dispensationalism. You could have everything He had even in the Dark Ages. When things got bad, God was trying to get light in.

Matthew 20:1 says:

| For the kingdom of heaven is like unto a man that is an householder, which went out early in the morning to hire labourers into his vineyard.

He is telling you how the kingdom of heaven operates. He is giving a parable so you can understand how He runs things.

The householder went early in the morning to hire laborers into his vineyard. If this parable is given in response to Peter's question--"We have left all to follow You; what do we get?"--then the vineyard is the kingdom, and the laborers are those who enter to work for Him.

Verse 2 says:

And when he had agreed with the labourers for a penny a day, he sent them into his vineyard.

And he went out about the third hour, and saw others standing idle in the marketplace, And said unto them; Go ye also into the vineyard, and whatsoever is right I will give you. And they went their way.

Again he went out about the sixth and ninth hour, and did likewise.

And about the eleventh hour he went out, and found others standing idle, and saith unto them, Why stand ye here all the day idle?

They say unto him, Because no man hath hired us. He saith unto them, Go ye also into the vineyard; and whatsoever is right, that shall ye receive.

He is sending men out among the harvest.

Peter says, "We have forsaken all in this life to follow You. We have entered Your vineyard. What do we get?"

Jesus says, "In this life, houses, lands, brothers, and sisters. They will be treasure in the next life. You will sit on thrones and rule. Many that are first shall be last, and the last first."

Then He gives the parable to help us understand.

Verse 8:

So when even was come, the lord of the vineyard saith unto his steward, Call the labourers, and give them their hire, beginning from the last unto the first.

And when they came that were hired about the eleventh hour, they received every man a penny.

But when the first came, they supposed that they should have received more; and they likewise received every man a penny.

The first were the ones hired at the first hour. Matthew 19:30 said the first will be last, and the last first. It looks as if we are locked into this: the ones who worked twelve hours come in last, and the ones who worked one hour come in first.

That confused me. Is there any good thing that came from working that long?

The best I could pull from those verses, if I left the rest alone, was the equality Jesus made by grace. It does not matter how long you worked, the inheritance is by grace.

We used examples like Sister Bar Hopper staggering into a storefront church, thinking she had found a beer party, getting born again, delivered, and healed in one service while the piano player who had been in every prayer line missed notes. The point was that healing and provision are by grace, not by how long you worked.

That is true when we are talking about benefits paid for by grace: healing, prosperity, peace, and provision. The moment I can receive them, they are mine. There is no set time limit. He would rather heal you the first day you lift your face toward heaven and want your miracle.

But Peter was asking about reward. He wanted to know what they got for leaving everything.

Heaven and getting to heaven are not based on how much God loves me. He loves the drunk who gets saved by the skin of his teeth and barely gets into heaven. He cannot love that man any less than He loves the apostle Paul.

Reward is not based on God's love for me. Reward is based on my love for Him. I do not call His love into question. I call my love into question.

How much reward I receive is based on how much of this life I forsake, how much I give over to Him, how much of myself I surrender.

For a long time I had these hallucination-like thoughts: "You are not going to make the big plunge, are you? You are not going to totally sell out with no reservations, are you? You are afraid of what you will give up here. You are afraid you cannot have the good life."

Norvel Hayes' first wife said something like that when God visited Norvel for an hour in his car and made him weep and cry. God asked him, "Will you follow Me?"

Norvel was a businessman. He said, "Yes, God, I will follow."

He came home looking pale, and she said, "What is wrong with you, Norvel? You look like you have seen a ghost."

He said, "God came into my car and stayed there about an hour."

She said, "What did He want?"

"He wants me to follow Him."

"Are you going to?"

"Yes, I am going to follow Him."

She was society: fine clothes, tea parties. Norvel made five thousand dollars a week fifty years ago. She loved that life. She said, "I know you, Norvel. You do not do anything halfway. We will end up in a hut in Africa. If you follow Him, I will leave you. What are you going to do?"

He said, "I am going to follow Him."

And she left him.

Now, near the end of her life, she is a mess. That is what can happen when you make a jump like that. That is where revival lives.

You make a jump like that, and you do not know what is out there. "Will that be the last day I have fun? Will I get tortured? What are You going to do with me? Send me where nobody goes?"

When you lose your life, you find it. It is not your own.

To become a servant, a minister, is a good reward if you are a servant. But to become a slave, to belong to Him, there is no higher goal. I am not talking about fivefold ministry. I am talking about a person totally giving their life.

We do not know what to expect. I have been separating myself to that, trying to reach that status of surrender. I do not know if I have done it or not. For a surrender like that, I have been calling on the power of the Holy Spirit:

"This is Your ministry. You have to help me. Help me die. I cannot do this myself. I am calling myself dead so Jesus may be exalted."

As far as I have gotten into this, I can tell you this much: the things I used to think were important are not. The things I used to think were not important are.

The things that really mean anything to me cannot be bought with money: my friends, my family. There is no greater moment than with those kinds of friends. Those things exist where men die, where they become faithful to one another. Faithfulness to one another is achieved only where there is faithfulness to the kingdom.

The things that really mean something to me live over there where I was afraid to go.

Benefits are by grace. Provision, healing, peace, all those things are mine by grace. But the reward is not His grace toward me. It is my surrender toward Him.

By grace, He can hand me all the benefits based on nothing I did. But not the reward.

I am glad the ball is in our court. I am glad we can have as much reward as we want. I do not want it chosen for me. Throw sovereignty out. Give me my day in court. Give me a chance to see how tough I am.

It takes strength to give this world up, with its fame, glory, and self-exaltation. Give me the chance to give it up. Put me in a hut with some Watusis if it means full reward. I do not care about this stuff, and I do not even want it.

Who wants to go with me?